

Windows Hello for faster and secure logins. Go to Settings > Accounts > Sign-in options and enroll your fingerprint and/or face. This not only makes login convenient but also adds security (biometrics are tied to your device and are harder to steal than a password). Also, ensure you have a strong Windows account password or PIN set. Under Accounts > Sign-in options, you can also enable Dynamic Lock (which auto-locks your PC when a paired phone goes out of range) if you want extra security when walking away. It's a good idea, too, to check Windows Security > Account Protection – it will prompt you if any of these account protections aren't set up. Following these steps helps prevent unauthorized access to your device.

10. **Install essential apps and run initial updates:** Now install any must-have applications you use daily (browser of choice, Office apps, creative tools, etc.). For each install, try to get them from reputable sources (Microsoft Store or the official website) to avoid malware. After installing, open each app and check for updates within the app (for example, Windows Store apps update through the Microsoft Store library; other apps often have “Check for updates” in Help menus). This ensures you start with the latest, most secure versions.
11. **Tweak power settings and fan profile:** Depending on your usage, adjust your power mode. For instance, if you need better battery life on the go, consider using the Windows power mode slider at “Best power efficiency” when on battery, and “Balanced” or “Best performance” when plugged in. (On Windows 11, this setting is in Settings > System > Power & battery > Power mode.) Many laptops also come with a manufacturer utility to switch performance profiles (e.g. Quiet, Balanced, Performance modes that control fan speed and CPU/GPU behavior). Now is a good time to put it in the mode that suits your typical use – perhaps “Balanced” for everyday work (which most makers set by default as a blend of performance and acoustics) or “Quiet”/“Silent” if you prefer absolute silence and longer battery at the cost of some performance. You can always toggle performance mode back on when doing heavy tasks. We'll dive deeper into fan profiles and performance tweaking in the next section, but ensure you know how to switch modes on your particular laptop (it might be a keyboard shortcut or in a preinstalled app like Lenovo Vantage, Dell Power Manager, ASUS Armoury Crate, etc.).
12. **Verify everything and create a restore point:** Finally, do a quick health check. Is the display brightness comfortable and color profile correct? Are audio, webcam, and other peripherals working? Connect to Wi-Fi and browse a bit to make sure networking is smooth. It's better to catch any hardware issues now when you can still return or exchange the laptop if needed. If all looks good, consider setting a manual Restore Point (Search “Create a restore point” > click Create) now that the system is in a clean, updated

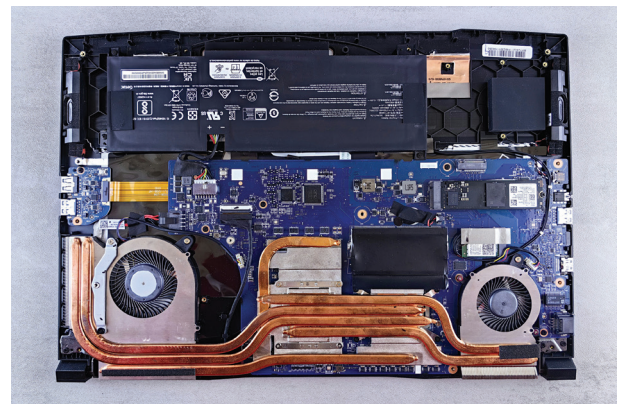
state. This snapshot can help you revert if a future change causes problems. Also, if you want an extra layer of backup, you might use the built-in Recovery Drive tool to create a USB recovery drive or image – optional but useful in case of drive failure.

By following these steps, you've addressed security (updates, antivirus, encryption, MFA), removed unwanted software, tuned privacy settings, and configured your laptop for optimal operation from day one. Next, let's look at caring for your battery and using performance features to ensure your device stays fast and healthy for the long haul.

Battery care: Myth vs Reality

Modern laptops use lithium-ion batteries, which are very different from the old nickel-based batteries – and yet, many myths about battery usage persist. Proper battery care can significantly extend the lifespan of your battery (meaning it will hold a good charge for more years), while bad habits can wear it out faster. Let's dispel a few common myths and establish best practices for battery longevity:

- **Myth: You should always discharge fully before recharging.** *Reality:* False. Unlike old Ni-Cad batteries that had “memory effect,” lithium-ion batteries do not need deep discharges – in fact, draining to 0% frequently is detrimental. It's best to keep the charge above ~20% whenever possible. Shutting down at 0% once in a while won't instantly kill the battery, but regularly running it bone-dry will strain the chemistry and shorten its lifespan. There is no need to “train” a Li-ion battery by cycling full 0–100% runs; that practice only wastes charge cycles.



- **Myth: Leaving the laptop plugged in 24/7 will overcharge or damage the battery.** *Reality:* Not exactly. You cannot overcharge a modern laptop battery by leaving it plugged in – the charging circuitry will stop charging at 100% and won't pump in more current. So you can't “overload” the battery. However, there is a catch: keeping a lithium battery at 100% all the time does put more stress on it over the long term. Batteries fare best when kept in the middle of their